

Even small libraries offer big selection in Latah County



George Williams

I've been a library user since I was 7 years old and I'm kind of used to big libraries with lots of rooms and tons of books. I got my first library card at the Idaho Falls Public Library back when it was in the old Carnegie building on the corner of Eastern Avenue and Elm Street - the building that is now the Museum of Idaho. When I was in the fifth grade the library moved to its new location on the corner of Broadway and Capital where it still stands - three floors of books, magazines, newspapers and all of the other crazy kinds of stuff you find in public libraries now.

When I was 17 I moved to Moscow and although the Moscow Public Library is much smaller than the Idaho Falls library, I not only had access to the public library, but the UI's library as well. And then for about six years I lived in Boise where I not only got to use, but also got to work at the Boise Public Library, the largest public library in the state. So, for my entire life, I've always lived somewhere near - usually within walking distance of - a large library.

But now I live in Troy. We moved to Troy last month because my wife works there and we were able to find a huge, affordable house there for much less than anything we looked at in Moscow. So now, for the first time in my life, I live in a town where the library is smaller than my house. And don't get me wrong - I love the library in Troy and all of the people who work there and I think it's a great library. It's just a lot smaller than the big public libraries I'm used to.

Of course, I'm not terribly worried about library services. I still work for the Latah County Library and in the last two weeks I've spent time working at the Deary, Bovill, Moscow, and Potlatch libraries. Quite frankly, I have just about all the library access I can put up with right now. But even if I didn't work at a library and wasn't heavily connected to the library world in a professional capacity, I don't think I'd be too worried about living in a town with a small library because of the Latah County Library District's commitment to sharing.

The Troy Community Library isn't just the Troy Library. It's just one of the seven branches of the Latah County Library District. While there may only be 8,444 items in the Troy Library, the Latah County Library owns 121,052 items that library users all over the county can access. And not only is the Troy Library part of the Latah County Library District, but it is also a part of VALNet which gives patrons of all seven of the Latah libraries access to the 753,448 items shelved at the 55 VALNet libraries. Latah Library patrons can request any of these items from any of these libraries or use their accounts at any of these locations.

Since VALNet is also a part of the Washington-Idaho Network of Libraries, Latah patrons can also request materials from the UI, LCSC, Gonzaga, Whitworth, or any other library that is part of the WIN system through the new WIN Borrow program. This includes CIN as well - a public library consortium much like VALNet that covers all of Benewah County, all of Kootenai County, and a big chunk of Bonner County as well as many other library districts to the north of us.

And finally, there is also a new service that is available to all Latah County Library patrons. As of this month, the Latah County Library District is a part of the Idaho State Library's "LiLi Express" program. LiLi Express is a cooperative program managed by the Idaho Commission for Libraries that allows card holders at participating Idaho libraries to get accounts at libraries in other parts of the state.

This means, for example, that when I go to visit my mother in Idaho Falls next week, I'll be able to go into the Idaho Falls Public Library, fill out an application through LiLI Express and get an IFPL account even though I live 560 miles away.

So, even though my new hometown library in Troy only has 8,444 items, I still have access to pretty much whatever I desire through the many cooperative programs that the Latah County Library District has committed to that allow me to get materials from many other libraries around the state.

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